

A Twist on Tradition:
Connections Between Physical Abnormalities, Ailments and Roman Morals in
Martial's *Epigrams*

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INTRODUCTION

Humour is an unmistakable part of mankind's existence. It comes in many forms, from the asinine to the completely silly to the tasteless. While the jokes have changed over the centuries, creating laughter from cleverly strung-together words has not. Martial (Marcus Valerius Martialis), a first-century Latin poet, was well-versed in the art of the written word. He is known as the creator of the modern epigram and is seen as being a large inspiration for Roman satire. Before Martial, epigram was seen as one of the lowest forms of poetry and lacking in creativity. Yet, he specifically chose it for what it could do such as providing a social commentary, even going so far as to announce his use of *epigramma* from the start. Epigram is known for its sharpness, typically involving invective while playing off of well-known comedic tropes and motifs. Sullivan states how it was "[Martial's] knuckle-down realism [and] his ingenuity at sketching the most scant and most caricatural of contours were indeed what gave the genre the "epigrammatic" style for which it is now known."¹ Martial has not only provided knowledge of everyday Roman society and customs but also has provided knowledge of many Roman obscenities. Obscenities were typically only seen in graffiti than in literature as obscene language was not meant for literature, but it was expected in an epigram. There was also an expectation for a certain amount of wit within epigrams. Martial's specific wit was like a puzzle sometimes that had to be decoded by his readers², like figuring out the culprit in an Agatha Christie novel or completing a logic puzzle.

As an author, Martial was not only providing commentaries on issues of morality and the typical individuals that are often seen as connected to these moral issues but

¹ J. P. Sullivan, *The Classical Heritage: Martial* (Garland, 1993), 186.

² Lindsay C. Watson and Patricia Watson, *Martial* (I.B. Tauris & Co, Ltd, 2015), 80.

was continuing literary traditions associated with typical motifs and tropes. While epigrams were used before Martial to provide social commentaries, such as Catullus had done when he wasn't writing lyric poetry, the most characteristic trait of modern epigram is its sharpness and satirical edge. Martial's use of jokes about ugly physical features was seen as a low form of humour, but then again, epigram was seen as a low form of poetry. Unlike previous epigrammatists, Martial did not put himself within his poems, but rather a literary persona. His comments were not so much his own, but the expectations that he was playing on as he connected with his audience by performing as a 'normal' male, although it can be said that his readers were "aware of the theatrical image underscoring Martial's poetic productions [while] he plays with the reader as he does with his world."³ The one thing a reader should always be aware of is that much of Martial's poetry is set during the Saturnalia, a winter festival known for excess and diseases and the perfect setting for his fictional world. Context is incredibly important when it comes to reading Martial as is his satirical edge, even though Roman satire had not yet been created. However, certain features within his epigrams have become common within satire such as sarcasm, double entendres, comparisons and exaggeration.

This essay will be focusing on a small set of his epigrams, ones that deal with the physiognomic theory that a person's outward appearance matches their inner personality. However, Martial takes it a step further in saying that a person's outward appearance (or their ailment) is connected with distorted or broken morals. For many who have not read Martial (or even Latin Literature in general), his work may appear confounding and rude at first, but he is simply using recurring and well-known themes

³ J. P. Sullivan and A. J. Boyle, *Martial in English* (Penguin, 1996), xx.

within ancient Rome and ancient Greece. According to Lindsay C. Watson in her work “Epigram” in *A Companion to Latin Literature*, there is much debate over whether Martial’s satire is powered by social criticism, a despairing moral nihilism, or simply to amuse⁴. However, what scholars do know is that Martial was writing for a specific audience, those he knew would read his poems which were the elite class. These were the people buying his works for either themselves or to recite during dinners with companions where word of mouth could make or break an artist. Wit is something that is typically associated with the elite or aristocracy.⁵ Something else to note is that conceivably none of the people within his epigrams were real, but he could have been using pseudonyms for real people. Although it is more likely that they are caricatures of typical people within Greco-Roman humour. As Peter Howell notes, “had these been identifiable as real people, he would have incurred risk.”⁶

Martial is well-known for his use of ‘the sting of the tail’ which is a phrase or word at the end of his epigram that is put there to shock the reader. Martial is also known for his use of obscenities which was frowned upon unless the author had to use it to get a point across. He saw the use of humour as a means of influence and even social communication.⁷ Martin notes that “by using irony, teasing, sarcasm, or satire to make fun of certain attitudes, behaviors, or personality traits, members of a group can communicate implicit expectations and rules concerning the kinds of behavior that are considered acceptable within the group.”⁸ His biting wit can be seen as almost a more aggressive form of teasing as it is “a mild form of censure, communicating disapproval

⁴ Lindsay C. Watson, “Epigram,” in *A Companion to Latin Literature*, ed. Stephen Harrison (Blackwell, 2005), 209.

⁵ Rod A. Martin, *The Psychology of Humor: An Integrative Approach* (Elsevier Academic Press, 2007), 23.

⁶ Peter Howell, *Ancients in Action: Martial* (Bristol Classical Press, 2009), 49.

⁷ Martin, 29.

⁸ Martin 119.

of some aspect of the target's habits, behaviors, or preferences."⁹ He took advantage of his readers' beliefs and through the use of humour he "[contributed] to the idioculture of a group, providing a way for members to construct a shared reality and sense of meaning."¹⁰ However, he's not influencing how they look at the world, but using already existing views and prejudices to influence them to buy his works. As stated earlier, he is playing the role of an everyday 'normal' male, one who finds humour in physical ailments and deformities and what those physical discrepancies may signal in terms of personalities and values.

It is obvious that in antiquity, writers were already aware that insult humour is "influenced by a set of implicit social rules regarding the appropriate targets, methods, and responses, which served to maintain self-esteem and a positive group climate."¹¹ Every society has its own unspoken rules and expectations for citizens. They are not so much drilled into people throughout their life, but rather the people are built around them. From Martial, readers can see the literary traditions that he continues in the form of physical humour. This form of humour is not something that Martial himself came up with, but that he saw in previous authors and had heard within Roman society. However, what Martial does impart is the notion that people are aware of where the boundaries of right and wrong lie within their society and how they view morals in a physical aspect. Mary Beard in *Laughter in Ancient Rome: On Joking, Tickling, and Cracking Up*, notes that "jokes are as much heuristic, intellectual devices as windows into the wellsprings of our unconscious."¹² Martial's poetry uses the shortcuts in the brain that lead to cognitive

⁹ Martin, 126.

¹⁰ Martin, 122.

¹¹ Martin, 122.

¹² Mary Beard, *Laughter in Ancient Rome: Joking, Tickling, and Cracking Up* (University of California Press, 2014), 54.

biases to base his works on. For ancient Rome, their social customs were known as the *mos maiorum*, a concept many who study Roman antiquity are well-versed in. The *mos maiorum* were different from written laws, but at the same time, they worked hand-in-hand with law-making and law-abiding.

For this essay, the *mos maiorum* will not be used by their Latin names, but rather by the concepts that they stand for. The first ones, to begin with, are those that deal with honesty, integrity, and reliability, such as *veritas* and *fides*. Some deal with personal discretion, responsibility and self-control known as *prudentia*, *gravitas*, and *severitas* and can range from oversharing one's sexual experiences to not having moderation in their desires and becoming greedy. Of course, social standing, respectability, stability, perseverance, and being cultured were also important and these ideals were *auctoritas*, *honestas*, *firmitas*, *constantia*, *industria*, and *humanitas*. Last, being an ideal male (*virtus*), having pride in oneself (*dignitas*), and being clean and healthy (*salubritas*) was important, especially to elite males, which made up the largest part of Martial's audience.

The characters that Martial uses to reinforce these values are not meant to represent average citizens but rather the elite (his readers) and those in the lowest parts of society like sex workers and then slaves. His use of sex workers comes as no surprise as "laughter was often associated with ancient prostitutes."¹³ Sex workers were always the butt of a joke because they were seen as only being good for one thing: sexual pleasure. The use of invective against them is endless, however, one of the things to remember when reading Martial is to not take what he says at face value¹⁴,

¹³ Beard, 45.

¹⁴ Howell, *Martial*, 73.

especially when it comes to physical deformities. A reader has to remember that Martial is portraying a persona that is meant for the readers of his Rome. He simply uses humour already associated with physical defects and ailments and “exploits the ugliness to make a joke”¹⁵ while drawing his readers into his fictional world.

Martial's constructed persona is that of a struggling writer trying to survive among the elite, who only wants to leave a peaceful life in the country. As William Fitzgerald puts it in his work *Martial: The World of the Epigram*, “as a professional epigrammatist his persona must be tinged with the character of the client...”¹⁶ and as a writer in antiquity, it is not surprising that as someone writing in the first-person, he would play around with his literary persona¹⁷, whether it was laughing at others or himself. To even begin to understand Martial, one has to align themselves with the humour of a past civilization. It is then that a person can finally begin reading Martial and understanding that what he says may not be what he thinks, but it's what sells his books and lends him an avenue for a comfortable life.

This essay will focus on how Martial in his collected work, *Epigrams*, used ailments and physical defects to reflect and commentate on Romans morals and societal standards. This topic came to mind as most of the in-depth studies of this topic come from the mid-twentieth century, with some related material in the twenty-first century. There is also the issue of the fact that academic knowledge of physical defects in Roman literature has changed over the years. While there is scholarship about physical defects within Roman literature, there is not much scholarship that specifically focuses on Martial's epigrams except for Lindsay Watson and Patricia Watson as well

¹⁵ Beard, 116.

¹⁶ William Fitzgerald, *Martial: The World of the Epigram* (University of Chicago Press, 2007), 8

¹⁷ Fitzgerald, 8.

as commentaries focused on specific books of Martial's, rather than the whole fourteen of them. When discussing this topic with others, it was interesting to note that not many students knew about the relationship between physical abnormalities and ailments and the broken morals that they stood for. It was also interesting to note how many people had not read Martial's epigrams in their entirety, but rather small snippets here and there, which is not enough to fully understand his sarcastic wit and his importance to modern epigram and even satire. Adding onto this is the fact that he was continuing many literary traditions, such as humorous tropes and themes. There is also a chance that if Martial had not decided to fully immerse himself in epigram, that it would have slowly died out and become nothing more than just another form of ancient literary prose. The text and translations I will be citing in this essay are from D. R. Shackleton Bailey's three-volume Loeb edition of Martial's *Epigrams*.

PART ONE: UGLY ON THE OUTSIDE AND THE INSIDE

INTRODUCTION

Romans, especially those who had the leisure time to enjoy small talk, enjoyed gossiping with one another. While much of Martial's writing deals with relationships between men - friendships, hosts and guests, and the patron and client relations - many epigrams feature physical abnormalities, something that is not directly featured in much scholarship. Their purpose is not as clear as Martial's other epigrams, such as those that discuss Domitian's revival of the Augustan adultery legislation which had serious penalties for sexual offences.¹⁸ Yet, his epigrams about physical defects demand a closer look, with their meaning hidden behind a cloak of dark humour. It is still meant to be insulting, but the invective is not as clear-cut as those which appear to be praising someone, yet are doing the exact opposite. This section will be focusing on how these physical defects are meant to be interpreted based on Roman and Latin knowledge.

First, it needs to be noted that there are physical deformities that differ depending on gender as Roman societal expectations were different for men and women. For example, there are defects such as one-eyedness which is typically attributed to females. However, there is some overlap among certain physical defects, especially those that relate to aging such as baldness, dentures, and cosmetics. Both men and women were meant to keep their egos in check because arrogance and vanity were not rewarded among even the elite, humbleness was.

¹⁸ Watson and Watson, *Martial*, 42.

While modern societies may view jokes about baldness and toothlessness as crude, they were widely enjoyed in Rome.¹⁹ Whether or not Martial found these jokes funny, he still used them as simple entertainment, well-known comedic tropes among his well-read elite patrons. As a Roman who lived during the time of Domitian's rule, an emperor known for his hypocrisy when it came to enacting laws that he did not follow, there is a large probability that Martial truly disliked hypocrisy among the elite and powerful. Potentially, Martial used epigrams, rather than another form of poetry to discuss moral failings and disrespect to social order in the open and without severe repercussions. Much like Oscar Wilde's novel *The Portrait of Dorian Gray*, Martial created characters whose corruption is presented physically. Vices of a person's personality are now presented as corporeal flaws for ridicule. His use of traditional motifs "[appealed] to loci ("what everybody knows") and the manipulation of expectation and fulfillment (the "conclusion") are, in short, at the heart of the designs behind Martial's epigrams, particularly those whose aim is to insult."²⁰

"HEAD"-ING IN THE RIGHT DIRECTION?

As already stated, there are physical flaws that are attributed to both men and women, typically referring to old age. These flaws are hair loss and tooth loss. Each is a true sign of old age but it is how Martial presents them and the personality of the character they belong to that is important. For men, old age is seen as a positive marker of life, a sign of wisdom, wealth and status among the elite, but it is only seen this way if they accept that they are no longer young. Baldness, for instance, is just another sign of

¹⁹ Howell, *Martial*, 74.

²⁰ Thomas Conley, *Toward a Rhetoric of Insult* (University of Chicago Press, 2010), 48.

ageing and yet it was a target for humour. However, for women, part of their attractiveness came from their hair, which changes due to ageing. Even if a woman wore a wig her whole life, its colour and style was expected to 'mature' just as her body did. By the time she becomes an old woman, her looks are no longer meant to impress and potentially woo suitors as her body is no longer able to safely produce children. While many epigrams deal with baldness, only a handful will be discussed in this section. The reason for baldness being discussed multiple times throughout Martial's books may be that he was secretly making fun of Domitian's supposed touchiness about his own baldness (Suet. *Dom.* 18.2), but there is no solid evidence to back up this theory as Domitian himself wrote about his own baldness.

In 6.74, Martial describes how a man sitting in the place of honour at a dinner party, the "lowest [seat] on the middle couch."²¹ A social climber who vainly attempts to keep up the appearance of a younger man by using a pate to comb over his remaining three hairs and by pretending to pick his non-existent teeth with toothpicks ("smothered sticks of mastic"²²). Watson and Watson note the use of three and four as the numbers used when describing the few remaining hair and teeth in not only Martial but also Lucian.²³ Martial in particular uses the number three as his choice when describing a character's few remaining hairs in other epigrams. Also noted is the fact that the compound, *trifilis*, is Martial's own creation²⁴, *tres* for 'three' and *filum* for 'thread' or 'hair'. This clever creation allows Martial to insert a more detailed description of the absurdity and comedy of the man's vainness.

²¹ Martial, *Epigrams*, ed. and trans. D. R. Shackleton Bailey (Harvard University Press, 1993), 59.

²² See note above.

²³ Lindsay C. Watson and Patricia Watson, *Select Epigrams* (Cambridge University Press, 2003), 319.

²⁴ See note 24.

In this next epigram, Martial directly calls out the character of Marinus (10.83) for trying to stay young with his last straggling hairs, instead of accepting that he is an old man now. Once again, Martial discusses vanity and loss of youthfulness among men.

*Raros colligis hinc et hinc capillos
et latum nitidae, Marine, calvae.
campum temporibus tegis comatis;
sed moti redeunt iubente vento
reddunturque sibi caputque nudum
cirris grandibus hinc et inde cingunt:
inter Spendophorum Telesphorumque
Cydae stare putabis Hermerotem.
vis tu simplicius senem fateri,
ut tandem videaris unus esse?
calvo turpius est nihil comato.*

“Marinus, you collect your scattered locks from this side and from that, and cover the broad expanse of your shining baldness with hair from your temples. But at the wind’s bidding they move and return and top with big curls on either side. You would think that Cydas’ Hermeros was standing between Spendophorus and Telesphorus. Why not be straightforward and admit to being an old man, so that at last you look like one man? Nothing is uglier than a baldhead with a lot of hair.”

The humour Martial creates is evident as the reader imagines Marinus' straggling hairs blowing in the breeze, also like a toupee in a strong windstorm. Hair has always been a standard of beauty, but baldness indeed allows for one to appear older and more distinguished. However, when one continues to pretend to be something they are not, they violate not only Roman values but they also lose the respect of their peers because of their dishonesty and vanity. Something that is of interest is that the name Hermeros is only used in this specific epigram, however, this may indicate even more that he is a slave who happens to be bald. Spendorphorus (9.56) and Telesphorus (11.26) are both mentioned to be young men in Martial's other poems, and most likely have curly hair as Martial describes the baldness in between two curly hairs on Marinus' head as being similar to Hermeros, a bald man, standing between these two young men. There is a connection between this epigram and 5.49 which describes a bald streak present on Labienus' head that makes him appear to be three people, young from the left and right side, but old when facing him head-on. In this way, a man's appearance can cause a sort of plurality to the person looking at them. They are old and yet try to come off as young, so much so that they appear to be two men instead of one. It is also interesting to note the use of another bald man in this epigram, one whose status is below Marinus' and yet he does not try to cover up his baldness. Perhaps that is because he cannot afford it, but the paradox is there. The sharp contrast between the two youthful men and the bald slave should also be noted when compared to Marinus, all of whom are each one man who stands on opposite ends of both age and social status. Yet, unlike Marinus, they do not pretend to be the wrong age but accept where they are in life.

Comb Overs were not the only way that men attempted to disguise their age, Martial also mentions the use of paint to create the appearance of hair. While these types of men may not have existed, as it is ridiculous to imagine men painting their hair on (6.57), the overall joke is the fact that this character, Phoebus, is bald and yet is calling the barber to shave his painted-on hair. Everyone knows what Phoebus won't admit to, that he isn't young anymore. He is not so much saying a bitter remark, but rather teasing about things that are commonplace to "reflect or sum up 'what everybody knows'."²⁵ Yet, Phoebus continues the lie by calling for a barber to 'shave' his head and Martial points out that "[a] sponge can shave you better, Phoebus."²⁶ As in, a razor is no good for liquids, even dried up liquids because that is the job of a rag. Another Phoebus, perhaps the same one, is also guilty of dishonesty in terms of his ageing head, except this Phoebus is using a wig, a kid's skin to be exact (12.45). This wig is so bad that someone wittily remarks on how well-shod his head is²⁷ marking how bad that wig was that it screams of Phoebus' dishonesty and vanity.

The other males that are specifically attempting to disguise their easily recognizable ageing heads are those that use dye to temporarily alter their ageing hair. that has been drained of its youthful colour so it is now white. Martial attacks the characters Laetinus (3.43) and Olus (4.36) for dyeing their hair that should obviously be white, but is somehow black. In particular, he calls out Olus for having black hair and a white beard, a glaringly obvious betrayal to his peers.

Cana est barba tibi, nigra est coma: tinguere barbam

non potes - haec causa est - et potes, Ole, comam.

²⁵ Conley, 39.

²⁶ Martial, *Epigrams*, 6.57.4

²⁷ Martial, *Epigrams*, 12.45.3-4.

“Your beard is white, your hair is black. You can’t dye your beard, Olus (this is the reason), and you can dye your hair.”

Shackleton Bailey notes that Olus’ beard cannot be dyed because of a possible skin disorder. There is obviously something stopping Olus from dyeing it, this is evident from the use of *potes* indicating that if he could dye his beard, he would.²⁸ It is also interesting to note that the punchline is within the first line of the epigram, rather than the last. This joke is obviously overused, a fact Martial is clearly aware of. He is also aware that his audience will know this joke right away and there is no need to go into specific details other than why Olus is not dyeing his beard. Martial has a larger bite when it comes to Laetinus in 3.43 where he says that Proserpina (the queen of the underworld) knows that his hair is white, not black, and will unmask his trickery soon enough, since he is close to dying. He begins the epigram similar to Olus where he contrasts his actual hair colour (white) with his falsely dyed colour (black), yet the sting is in the last sentence this time, rather than the first. In a way, both Olus and Laetinus are similar to the balding men in 10.83 and 5.49 where they appeared to be more than one man, youthful at one angle and old at another. These men are not accepting their age and are not presenting truthfulness towards themselves and towards others, which goes against certain morals and makes it hard for other men to put their faith into them when they both refuse to accept that they are aging.

Men are not the only ones who lose their hair, women do as well as Martial indicates, though not as often as men. It is more likely that Martial is using hair loss to be an easy indicator of age, rather than just outright saying that a woman is old as there are many epigrams that already do so. Like baldness and aging in men, making fun of

²⁸ Rosario Moreno Soldevila, *Martial, Book IV: A Commentary* (Brill, 2006), 284.

women who are well past their prime yet pretending to be otherwise was part of both epigram and satire. In general, it is making fun of old women that antiquity enjoyed. Even in ancient Greece, the old woman was a comedic trope, just as much as the balding man was. Perhaps it was the fact that age was seen as a physical disturbance in antiquity, although it could also be the fact that antiquity enjoyed making fun of those who were vulnerable. Whatever the case, antiquity found this type of insult humour appealing and Martial simply took that appeal and laid it out on paper for his readers to enjoy.

One of his more puzzling epigrams dealing with baldness in women is 12.7. Martial creates an interesting juxtaposition by describing how Legeia is bald with only three hairs on her head, which means that she should be like a three-year-old child. The bizarreness of this joke lies in the fact that baldness in adults is an indication of old age, rather than youth.

Toto vertice quot gerit capillos

annos si tot habet Ligeia, trima est.

“If Ligeia has as many years as she carries hairs on her entire head, she is three years old.”

Unlike the balding men described earlier, Ligeia is not guilty of deceit or vanity, she is simply guilty of being old and being part of a literary tradition where older women are the butt of a joke. She is also a part of a literary twist made by Martial where a reader would expect her to have lots of hair on her head since she is presumably old and yet Martial twists the reader's expectation to the fact that one cannot use physical units of a body to indicate age, but they can use the lack of physical units to do so. Yet, it is

obviously meant to be a slight against older women and the brevity of the two-word conclusion only heightens the insult. However, a paradox lies in the comparison between Ligeia and a child, where they both have three hairs and yet one has just started their life and the other is nearing the end of theirs. One can assume that from the joke that Ligeia is a woman who is trying to lie about her age as is seen in so many female characters present in Martial's epigrams.

For anyone who sees a wig that obviously does not match the age of its wearer, there is always this underlying question: "Do they think we're not aware that it's not a wig on top of all those wrinkles?" Fabulla is introduced as a female character who is not only guilty of lying about her obviously fake hair, but also of perjury since she swears that it is her own (6.12).

Iurat capillos esse, quos emit, suos

Fabulla: numquid, Paule, peierat?

"Fabulla swears that the hair she buys is her own. Is that perjury, Paulus?"

Like men, she dismisses the Roman value of honesty, yet Martial takes it a step further by asking if she is committing perjury. Perhaps she is as she is allowing her own vanity to control her actions. If the scales of justice were to weigh her consciousness, she would be guilty of living a lie. Fabulla had the choice to push aside the comment that her hair is fake, rather than to outright lie that it wasn't. We also see mention of Paulus, a character already featured in 2.20, who said that the poems he purchased were his own and Martial agrees that they are physically his because he bought them, but that they are not his own creations and that he is guilty of plagiarism. Again, Martial is attacking

this poet, but indirectly this time by connecting Fabulla's lies to his own and noting the similarities in mock comparison. However, while Paula is paying for vanity, Paulus is paying for authorship. She cannot accept that she has aged, and he cannot accept that he is talentless. Or, at least, that is what Martial would like us to believe as he tends to attack poets who attack him and/or plagiarise his work.

Hair was not the only marker of age, teeth were as well, or at least, the loss of teeth was the indicator of age. Within Martial's epigrammatic world, there are many mentions of false teeth (dentures), but rather than being used to chew, these false teeth were used in the pursuit of vanity. In the real world, false teeth were needed for everyday living as dental hygiene was not as advanced in ancient Rome, but for Martial, it is another physical representation of vanity and dishonesty among the elite. The loss of teeth itself is connected to both ageing and the perceived ugliness of ageing. However, dentures are not only used by the elderly, but also by sex workers in hopes that by increasing their attractiveness, they will gain more clients.

Within 9.37, Martial writes about Galla, a sex worker who uses not only false teeth but also a wig and makeup that she purchased at the market to make herself more physically attractive. However, she does not do this for her clients, but herself. This becomes clear when the reader realises that her vagina is not shaved, the part of her body that her client is most interested in and is paying for. Shackleton Bailey notes the connection to 6.23 where Martial says that no matter how much Lesbia tries to seduce him and his penis, her ugliness is the actual problem. Just like Lesbia, Galla promises a good time to Martial, yet he and his personified penis are both aware that Galla is ugly on both the inside and the outside. Not only is she a low-class citizen, but she has the

gall to be vain. It is interesting how Martial states that he is not in control of his penis, but that even it is not interested in these women. It may be deaf and not able to hear Galla's promises, but as Martial says to Galla, "though it be one-eyed, it sees you."²⁹ As a sex worker, she already struggles with money and yet instead of buying food or other necessities, she spends it on her appearance.

The loss of teeth and the use of dentures is not the only unattractive thing about teeth. Martial also discusses how they can be black, another dental reality of ancient Rome due to the lack of knowledge surrounding dental hygiene. Although, perhaps in Martial's world, black teeth are an indicator of an unhealthy lifestyle or career. In 5.43, Martial cleverly rolls two well-known jokes into one, yet it is puzzling because the reader is left to decide whether one flaw is worse than the other. He discusses Thais, a woman whose name suggests that she is a sex worker³⁰ and a well-off one at that, and Laecania, an aristocratic woman³¹. This epigram is both short and witty, a true Martial classic, with only two lines and yet a stinging invective.

Thais habet nigros, niveos Laecania dentes.

Quae rhytio est? Emptos haec habet, illa suos.

"Thais' teeth are black, Laecania's snow-white. The reason?

The one has those she bought, the other her own."

The double insult in Latin is clear by the use of *haec* which indicates Laecania and *illa* which indicates Thais. Thais' teeth are black because she is a sex worker, while Laecania bought her teeth to replace the ones that age took away. What is interesting to note is that one would think that as a well-off sex worker Thais would have the

²⁹ Martial, *Epigrams*, 9.37.10.

³⁰ Watson and Watson, *Select Epigrams*, 15.

³¹ Evidence of her social standing in 7.35 as she owns a slave.

resources to care for her teeth, especially since the use of her mouth was important for her job when it came to giving oral sex to clients, yet they are black. If her teeth are black, then where is her money going? Although Martial could also be saying that her mouth is dirty from the immoral acts she performs daily. In Rome, oral sex was frowned upon as Romans believed their mouths were and should remain pure. Giving oral sex was worse than receiving it because it was an immoral act that went against their beliefs. Therefore, it should be considered that Thais' black teeth are a physical indication of her career and something that would have marked her as an unmarriageable woman. There is not much to add when it comes to Laecania as she is yet another elite woman whose vanity and desire to appear young again has made her purchase snow-white teeth that do not match her appearance. However, Martial does place these two women on a sort of spectrum of immorality whether it is worse to be a woman who sells her body or to be a vain woman.

“EYE” CAN’T BELIEVE MY EYES

A repeated motif in Martial's epigrams is the one-eyed woman. One-eyedness can be viewed as yet another indication of age, although it can also be a simple way to call a woman ugly. It is typically ascribed to mock women, however, it has also been used to describe a penis as being one-eyed in 9.37 and avarice in 6.78 among others. There is no specific group of women that it is connected with as it is seen when mocking a *tribade*, a sex worker, and an older woman. One-eyedness is a satiric motif, yet is not seen in many epigrams outside of Martial, although with how much Martial uses this

motif within his epigrams, one-eyedness was not something Martial simply imagined.³² For invective poetry, one-eyedness tended to be a very typical insult, albeit a low form of insult, just like epigram was a low form of poetry so they went hand-in-hand.

Three of Martial's epigrams that include one-eyedness were targeted at a character called Philaenis (2.33 .8, 4.65, 12.22). Throughout his epigrams, Martial showcases Philaenis as ugly and unworthy of affection, most likely because of her crime of being a *tribas*, which is a masculine lesbian who is an active sexual partner, rather than a passive partner. In antiquity, women are seen as always being the passive sexual partner as they are meant to receive and not give. However, Philaenis refuses to receive and she is even more guilty because she performs oral sex on women, even after stating that she doesn't perform fellatio on men (7.67). The first epigram to feature a one-eyed Philaenis is in the form of Martial's common question/answer format. In it, Martial is explaining all the reasons why he won't kiss Philaenis (2.33), the overall main point being that he finds her unattractive in general.

Cur non basio te, Philaeni? Calva es.

Cur non basio te, Philaeni? Rufa es.

Cur non basio te, Philaeni? Lusca es.

Haec qui basiat, o Philaeni, fellat.

"Why don't I kiss you, Philaenis? You are bald. Why don't I kiss you, Philaenis? You are rubicund. Why don't I kiss you, Philaenis? You are one-eyed. He who kisses these things, Philaenis, sucks."

³² Patricia A. Watson, "Martial's Fascination with 'Lusci,'" in *Greece & Rome* 29, no. 1 (1982): 75, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/642932>.

This epigram is particularly enjoyable to look at in both Latin and English because of its repetition, most likely because it is in hendecasyllabics³³, and yet it packs a big punch for only four lines. Philaenis appears to be the exact opposite of everything that a man wants, she doesn't have flowing hair, her face is not symmetrical, and she is not fair-skinned. This character is a complete inversion of Roman beauty standards and rather than being feminine, she comes off as masculine. Perhaps for Philaenis, her one-eyedness is also an indicator of her desire to be an active sexual partner. Her baldness may also be a symptom of her masculinity as described by Seneca (*Epist.* 95). Interestingly enough, Philaenis is both bald (*calva*) and red-headed (*ruba*) and she cannot be both. By describing Philaenis in this way (and in other ways), Martial is attempting to persuade other men to avoid Philaenis because she is no good as a woman, nor as a man.

In 4.65, Philaenis is once again one-eyed in a witty two-liner. It is now evident that Martial is using this name consciously as a connection to the fourth-century BC Greek poet, Philaenis, who was said to be a *tribas*. Perhaps being one-eyed does equate to being masculine, but it is hard to tell with this particular epigram because it feels like there is some joke that modern readers do not catch onto.

Oculo Philaenis semper altero plorat.

quo fiat istud quaeritis modo? lusca est.

“Philaenis always weeps from one eye. Do you ask how that is? She has but one.”

Commentaries for this epigram are lacking as there could be a double meaning for both *semper...plorat* and *lusca est*. The evidence for this is that *ploro* is not typically used to

³³ Craig A. Williams, *Martial Epigrams Book Two* (Oxford University Press, 2004), 128.

describe weeping, *lacrimo* is, and yet it is also used in 4.58 as Galla is said to mourn for her dead husband in private, rather than in public because she is ashamed that she is unable to shed any actual tears for him. What commentaries can see with this epigram is that it is a very classical Martial epigram, with two lines and a two-word punchline. A punchline that modern readers are missing, although it is most likely a penis joke that is attempting to scorn Philaenis for her relationships with women, especially during a time where women are expected to marry men to have their children.

The next epigram to depict Philaenis is very similar to 2.33 because it is both short and in hendecasyllabics. In 12.22, Martial discusses Philaenis' one-eyedness with his friend Fabullus, although unlike previous epigrams describing her one-eye as being a physical description of masculinity, this epigram seems to be attacking her attractiveness.

*Quam sit lusca Philaenis indecenter
vis dicam breviter tibi, Fabulle?
esset caeca decentior Philaenis.*

“Do you want me to tell you in a nutshell how uncomely
Philaenis is with her one eye, Fabullus? Philaenis would be
more comely if she were blind.”

While Martial may not view Philaenis (or any other one-eyed woman) as attractive, this epigram is attractive in terms of its pattern, two lines for the build-up and then one line for the punchline. It is also interesting how he says that this character would be more attractive if she had no eyes, rather than just the one. One can imagine that attractiveness in Martial's Rome would have included symmetrical faces, such as having

either two eyes or no eyes, rather than just one. There is something about the one-eyed woman that Martial's audience enjoyed or maybe it is just the fact that he shows little mercy when it comes to disabilities.

The other epigrams to include one-eyed females are all very different from one another. To begin, Martial mocks the romantic interest that the character Quintus shows in one-eyed Thais (3.8). He makes sure to not confuse his readers as to which Thais he is discussing as there are two.

Thaida Quintus amat. 'Quam Thaida?' Thaida luscum

Unum oculum Thais non habet, ille duos.

"Quintus loves Thais. "Which Thais?" One-eyed Thais. Thais lacks one eye, he lacks two."

Martial is not so much making fun of Thais here as his goal is to ridicule Quintus for his choice of women. Martial uses her unattractiveness as a play on the idea of the lover's blindness.³⁴ He also plays on the concept of literal and metaphorical blindness, although making the beloved have one eye seems to be an original thought by Martial.³⁵ Out of all the women Quintus could have chosen, he fell for a woman who doesn't even have two eyes and is also a sex worker. As already mentioned earlier, Thais is a common name for sex workers as evident from the fact that someone has to ask which Thais Martial is referring to. However, even with one eye, she has managed to snag a recurring client that she can benefit materially from and she will continue to do so as long as he is blind to her apparent unattractiveness. Whereas Quintus, since he is in love with her, may not be doing his duty to Rome, such as fathering legitimate children,

³⁴ Watson and Watson, *Select Epigrams*, 326.

³⁵ See note above.

although this idea may be far-reaching since there is no indication whether Quintus is married or not, although there is a Quintus who married a Laelia in 5.75.

This last epigram features the question/answer format and discusses Laelia (perhaps the same Laelia of 5.75) who appears to have lost her eyesight completely and unlike her teeth and hair, she cannot buy eyes to replace those that she has lost (12.23).

Dentibus atque comis - nec te pudet - uteris emptis.

quid facies oculo, Laelia? non emitur.

“You bought teeth and hair and are not ashamed of it. What will you do with your eyes, Laelia? That’s not to be bought.”

This epigram comes directly after 12.22 which discusses one-eyed Philaenis, but rather than be one-eyed, Laelia is losing eyesight in both eyes. Laelia is an older woman with an actual problem with not only her eyes but has also lost her hair and teeth. Unlike her hair and teeth, this is a problem she cannot fix nor cover up with a false replica as seeing is a sense, not a physical trait. Just like every other joke made about aging, “modern sensibilities are apt to be shocked by Martial’s jokes about the unfortunates who are blind...or have only one eye...”³⁶ because it is something that people should pity, rather than joke about. However, the humour in this situation is that Laelia is trying to stay as young as possible by lying about her outward appearance as much as she can. Once again we see a vain woman who is attempting to stay young by spending her money to deceive people and from her lies she distorts and misuses the values of frugality and truthfulness. Yet, she cannot hide the one sign of aging that she cannot buy, the loss of her eyesight.

³⁶ Sullivan, *Martial: An Unexpected Classic* (Cambridge University Press, 1991), 168.

PART TWO: NO PAIN, NO GAIN

INTRODUCTION

Physical abnormalities are not the only way that Martial discussed moral issues, certain bodily injuries and diseases were also used to describe and discuss issues such as greed and deceit. Such examples include gout and consumption, both of which will be discussed in this section. There is much material on not only the imagined forms of these bodily issues but also the reality of them and their effect on people within antiquity. Such material includes Galen who wrote about issues like gout and how to tell if someone was faking it or not. Presumably, this was a problem in antiquity and without proper treatment and medication, like those that are available in the modern world, it was sure to have been an extremely painful issue. That isn't to say that it is not an issue even today, but that just like dental issues, other bodily issues were not as easily treatable.

While similar to physical abnormalities, physical ailments are different when it comes to the moral issues they typically coincide with. However, they are another form of physical humour within antiquity and another literary and comic tradition that Martial takes part in. Physical ailments like gout or even consumption are also seen later in satire and are considered satirical themes. While Martial was simply using the resources available to him from his society to create his epigrams, he was still a 'modern' source at the time for this type of dark humour full of wit and sarcasm. Therefore paving the way for future wit involving all the parts of satire from comparison to juxtaposition.

YOU “GOUTTA” HAVE IT IF YOU WANNA MAKE IT IN THE WORLD

Gout is a very common form of arthritis that typically affects that foot, specifically the big toe and is caused by an excess of uric acid in the bloodstream. It is very painful because the affected area, typically the foot, can swell and become extremely tender. It is not a pleasant experience and can affect anyone. It becomes worse with alcohol, sugars and red meat. It is also a satirical theme that Martial uses, typically for overly decadent men. Gout is also a well-used satirical joke used in antiquity³⁷ that has been seen in works done by Horace, Vergil, and Seneca and as stated before, is part of the many comic traditions that Martial set his fictional world in and around.

In 1.98, Martial describes Diodorus, a man suffering from not only gout in his feet (*podagra*), but also in his hand (*cheragra*). Diodorus is yet another avaricious suffering from a disease that is consistently connected to wealth within Greco-Roman literature.

Litigat et podagra Diodorus, Flacce, laborat.

sed nil patrono porrigit: haec cheragra est.

“Flaccus, Diodorus goes to law and suffers with gout in the feet. But he gives nothing to his counsel. That’s gout in his hand”

This epigram is a great example of the wordplay done by Martial with the homophones *podagra* and *cheragra*³⁸. However, Martial is also discussing the continued stinginess of men when it came to paying for their legal fees, even after the passing of the *Lex Cincia*. Emperor Claudius capped legal fees at 10,000 sesterces, and according to

³⁷ Watson and Watson, *Martial*, 109.

³⁸ Sullivan, *Martial: The Unexpected Classic*, 247.

Quintilian, advocates could not ask for the fee, it was all based on the client's generosity.³⁹ According to Roman authors, being a lawyer was a thankless career where the advocate did not make that much money even though he was in a specialised role. This epigram shows that that is no exception as the client, Diodorus, says that he cannot pay because not only does he have gout in his feet, but also in his clenched hand. Conceivable, Martial may also be stating that the greedier and cheaper Diodorus is, the more his gout travels. Physical pain in place of the values that Diodorus distorts such as frugality and honour.

As mentioned much earlier, Martial wrote many of his epigrams about relationships between men, such as the patron and client relationship. In 7.39, Martial combines both the traditional mockery of gout in the feet and the concept of the *salutatio*. This epigram is an example of a patron and client relationship involving the morning greeting that a client would give to his patron at the patron's house. Some clients would have multiple patrons and would be hustling all around the city to greet every patron. Caelius was one of these clients who could no longer tolerate having to run around and greet every patron in the morning, so he decided to fake having gout. He even went as far as to bandage his feet and fake having a painful gait. The humour lies in his last line which echoes a verse used earlier in the poem where "*coepit fingere Caelius podagram*" has now become "*desit fingere Caelius podagram*". Martial and his readers have the last laugh as Caelius no longer has to pretend to have gout in his feet because he now has it for real, most likely due to living lavishly and not respecting the ancient custom of *salutatio*. He has been struck by karma with the physical illness being a physical manifestation of living beyond his means without paying respect to his

³⁹ Martial, *Epigrams*, 12.7.11-12

patron(s) who help provide his lifestyle. Vioque notes that the epigram has two parts, the introduction of the topic and the humorous denouement.⁴⁰

The other epigrams that mention gout are 9.92 and 12.48 where indulgence in luxury is evident. In 9.92, Martial contrasts the problems of a slave, Condylus, and his master, Gaius, stating that the rich have it worse than the poor, a true satirical statement. He describes how the free have to worry about thieves stealing their property, paying respect to their patrons, gout, and depravity. Whereas a slave does not need to greet his own master, there is no expectation for it at all. Martial says that compared to his master, Condylus has it easy, as luxury is more a curse than a blessing as greed in Martial's world can manifest in bodily aches and pains. In 12.48, Martial says much the same thing where he describes the dangers of eating and living luxuriously. He describes the gout and jaundice one can acquire from such living and the dangers that gluttony and greed in general have on one's health and presumably one's moral consciousness.

COUGARS VERSUS GOLD DIGGERS

Within Martial's poetry, there is evidence of consumption or at least some sort of pulmonary disease present, that is typically associated with older women. For some of these women, they are indeed very close to death, yet for others, they are simply pretending to be close to death to gain a suitor. These suitors are legacy hunters (*captatio*) who are looking for an easy way to make money from the estates of these supposedly soon-to-be-dead matrons. Martial's discussion of legacy hunters is one of his most inconsistent themes as he mocks those who would deceive women in this way

⁴⁰ Guillermo Galan Vioque, *Martial, Book VII: A Commentary* (Brill, 2002), 259.

for their greed, yet in 10.8 he states that he would not be against marrying a very old woman. Legacy hunters were not uncommon in Rome, especially after the birth rate declined which left many women without children, therefore their inheritance would go to close family or friends, or in this case, a fortune hunter.

In 1.10, one of Martial's first epigrams, he first introduces the concept of the male fortune hunter who is looking for an easy payday. His target is an older woman dying from a terminal pulmonary illness.

*Petit Gemellus nuptias Maronillae
et cupit et instat et precatur et donat.
adeone pulchra est? immo foedius nil est.
quid ergo in illa petitur et placet? tussit.*

"Gemellus is a-wooing Maronilla. He is eager and insistent, begs her, gives her presents. Is she such a beauty? On the contrary, she couldn't be uglier. So what is so desirable about her, so attractive? Her cough."

According to Peter Howell's commentary of Book One, this is one of Martial's most celebrated epigrams as it fully represents Martial's art.⁴¹ This comes as no surprise as Martial uses a well-used joke, but puts his twist on it where the reader cannot figure out why Gemellus would possibly be wooing Maronilla until we see the one-word punchline. The build-up is well worth the simple and yet effective punchline. It is from here that the reader realises that Maronilla is dying from consumption. After this, her attractiveness becomes apparent since the reader can assume that she is wealthy and will be leaving her inheritance soon, an inheritance that Gemellus is hoping will be his. Two things to

⁴¹ Peter Howell, *A Commentary on Book One of the Epigrams of Martial* (The Athlone Press, 1980), 128.

note with this poem is the use of two questions and the one-word punchline, both of which are uncommon in Martial. Although scholars can assume if they were more common, then they would become wearisome from overuse.⁴² Again, Martial is not the first person to use this type of humour, especially when it comes to older women as they were a favourite target of invective in antiquity. It is quite evident that Gemellus is nothing more than a greedy man who is obsessed with the concept of material wealth. He is neither frugal nor is he honest in his supposed attraction to Maronilla, a fact that everyone in Martial's world and beyond is aware of.

In 2.26, we see another example of a fortune hunter, however, this time it is not the old woman being tricked, but the man. It is a clever inversion where Naevia is not sick, she is simply an old woman who is aware that if she pretends to be dying, she will attract a suitor, or possibly multiple suitors. Although this is not apparent within the poem, it is not out of the realm of reality.

*Quod querulum spirit, quod acerbum Naevia tussit,
inque tuos mitti sputa subinde sinus,
iam te rem factam, Bithynice, credis habere?
erras: banditur Naevia, non moritur.*

“Naevia wheezes, she has a dry cough, she often sends spit
into your lap. Bithynicus, do you think you have it made?
You’re wrong. Naevia is coaxing, not dying.”

It has been suggested that Bithynicus may already be Naevia's lover and that she is pretending to be near death so that he will do whatever she asks.⁴³ However, this

⁴² Howell, *Commentary*, 129.

⁴³ Williams, 104.

seems to be more speculation than fact as it is never explicitly stated that Naevia is making Bithynicus do tasks, other than to comfort her. His comforting her is evident from the nearness indicated by the fact that Naevia's spittle can end up on Bithynicus' lap. The use of *erras* creates the inversion of the poem and drives the point home that Bithynicus is the one being tricked, rather than the trickster. Neither Bithynicus nor Naevia are being honest with one another, nor anyone else, although Martial suggests that people who know Naevia well know that she is not close to dying. Interestingly, the phrase *mittit sputa*, is seen in no other surviving Latin text but is a periphrasis for *sputat* or *sputit*.⁴⁴ There may also be a sexual undertone by the use of *blanditur*, which can be a sexually charged word and probably is based on the context of this specific poem.

The poem 9.80 is very interesting in the fact that it depicts not so much a legacy hunter, but a poor man who was coaxed into marrying a rich older woman. It is a variation on the trope of the legacy hunter and the sex-starved older woman.⁴⁵

*Duxerat esuriens locupletem pauper anumque:
uxorem pascit Gellius et futuit.*

“A hungry pauper, Gellius married a rich old woman. He
feeds his wife and fucks her.”

Shackleton Bailey notes the meaning of feeding to be referring to *irrumat*, a violent sexual act. While Gellius may have been uncomfortable fellating an older woman, conceivably, he would have enjoyed it as this sexual act was seen as the peak of male sexual cravings. The difference between Gellius and the previous men is that he is a very poor man looking to survive, while the other men were already rich and were

⁴⁴ Williams, 105.

⁴⁵ Christer Henriksen, *A Commentary on Martial, Epigrams, Book 9* (Oxford University Press, 2012), 321.

greedily looking for more money and property. The other difference is that Gellius married his older woman, while the other men did not. The reader can sense that Gellius may not be happy in the marriage but endures having sex with an older woman so that she will continue to support him.⁴⁶ The humour lies in the inversion of the legacy hunter and that the reader is seeing yet another example of an older woman using her wealth to coax a man into her home, and in this instance, her marriage bed. The older woman is seen as the initiator of this entire relationship and the greedier individual, but Gellius is just as greedy as she is, except that he is after a comfortable life. Another part of the humour lies in the paradox between a pauper being able to feed his wife food, which the reader realises is describing a sort of transaction of sex for a comfortable life.

⁴⁶ See note 45.

PART THREE: EXPECT THE UNEXPECTED

INTRODUCTION

While morals are often connected with physical abnormalities and ailments, they can also be connected with beautiful people. As seen earlier, vanity can cause a shift in the humbleness expected of a Roman citizen, so it is not that surprising that Martial remarks on not only unattractive people but attractive people as well. Although that's not all that he discusses, there are also occurrences of Martial describing himself and his securities within the realm of his fictional world. These specific poems tend to be set in the baths. Within these scenes, he invites his readers to laugh at him, rather than with him. This is very interesting because it almost levels the playing field since he integrates himself, or at least his literary persona, into his poems. His self-deprecating humour further illustrates that everything about his books is meant for humour and not for actual malice. Although his Roman readers would have already been aware that everything said was done so in a fictional manner. This section will serve as a juxtaposition to the exaggeration of physical deformities previously discussed because "in the ancient world (and perhaps not only there) it was an essential corollary of the fact that certain people were to be praised [and] that others should be blamed,"⁴⁷ Yet Martial shows that there are two sides to the coin.

YOU'RE SO VAIN

Ancient Rome did not take well to any form of arrogance, including people who outrightly state their attractiveness (or supposed attractiveness). Women especially

⁴⁷ Fitzgerald, 100.

were meant to be modest and not vain, particularly when it came to their appearance. They could be coy, but they could not be outright flirtatious or arrogant in their appearance. Just like the older women who attempted to make themselves more appealing, presumably for themselves, women who were already beautiful could also be guilty of vanity.

In 1.64, Martial talks about Fabulla, who boasts so much of her beauty, youth, and wealth, that she has become repellent to those around her and her merits have become outweighed by her continual boasting.

*Bella es, novimus, et puella, verum est,
et dives, quis enim potest negare?
sed cum te nimium, Fabulla, laudas,
nec dives neque bella nec puella es.*

“You are pretty: we know. You are young: true. And rich: who can deny it? But when you praise yourself too much, Fabulla, you are neither rich nor pretty nor young.”

It has been noted that this poem is very Catullan with its use of the phrase *bella puella*.⁴⁸ What is interesting is that the name used here is the same one used in 6.12 to describe a woman who lied about her wig being her real hair. Potentially this is the same Fabulla as there are other poems written by Martial which describe an old woman named Fabulla who is attempting to look young. Perhaps that is the trick though, because why else is a woman singing her praises so much if she is indeed wealthy and young and beautiful. Perhaps this is why Martial commented on 6.12 asking if her lies were perjury as this Fabulla (or maybe all the Fabullas) tended to lie about their

⁴⁸ Howell, *Commentary*, 258.

appearance(s). However, she could indeed be young but simply act like the other Fabulla who is old and unattractive and lies about her appearance to others and potentially herself. If this Fabulla is acting like an old woman, then there is a large chance that she, like older women in Martial's world, is looking for a suitor to satisfy her needs. Yet, by boasting so much, she would lose the interest of any suitors because it makes her look like she's trying too hard and lacks any sense of humbleness and frugality. Her lack of self-control when it comes to what she should and should not say leads to her acting like the poor and ugly older women that Martial jests at so much.

In 5.45, Martial once again writes about a woman, Bassa, who also boasts about herself with Martial contradicting her by saying that only those who are the exact opposite of beautiful and young say that they are beautiful and young.

Dicis formosam, dicis te, Bassa, puellam.

istud quae non est dicere, Bassa, solet.

"You say you are beautiful, Bassa, you say you are a girl.

That is usually said by somebody who is neither, Bassa."

As we have seen previously when discussing older women who were either wearing wigs or applying makeup or using false teeth (or all), these women were all saying and attempting to portray that they were still young, yet their lack of honesty and trustworthiness is clear. The character of Bassa may say that she is a young and beautiful girl, but surely from her face Martial can tell that she is indeed old and unattractive. Once again, Martial attacks this character for her pride and vanity and the fact that she is a hypocrite.

ANYTHING BUT THE CHILDREN!

As mentioned early on, during Domitian's rule he renewed the Augustan marriage legislation which included steep penalties for adulterers. Within Rome, adultery is considered a moral failing and yet is seen most commonly among the elite. This caused issues when it came to having legitimate children and carrying on family lines. An issue Domitian believed could be fixed by renewing this old law. Eligible young women were expected to marry as soon as possible and all men were expected to marry to continue on their bloodlines and to add to the amount of legal Roman citizens. This section will be focusing on one epigram which depicts Cinna and his wife Marulla and their seven children (6.39). The problem that Cinna is facing is that none of the children are his, but are in fact children of his slaves. Watson and Watson note "the use of typically aristocratic names for the couple - Cinna and Marulla - not only announces their social class but serves to underscore the disparity in status between the wife and her lovers."⁴⁹

*Pater ex Marulla, Cinna, factus es septem
non liberorum: namque nec tuus quisquam
nec est amici filiusve vicini,
sed in grabatis tegetibusque concepti
materna prudent capitibus suis furta.
hic qui retorto crine Maurus incedit
subolem fatetur esse se coco Santrae
at ille sima nare, turgidis labris
ipsa est imago Pannychi palaestritae.*

⁴⁹ Watson and Watson, *Select Epigrams*, 245.

*pistoris esse tertium quis ignorant,
 quicumque lippum novit et videt Damam?
 quartus cinaeda fronte, candido vultu
 ex concubino natus est tibi Lygdo:
 percide, si vis, filium: nefas non est.
 hunc vero acuto capite et auribus longis,
 quae sic moventur ut solent asellorum,
 quis morionis filium negat Cyrtae?
 duae sorores, illa nigra et haec rufa,
 Croti choraulae vilicique sunt Carpi.
 iam Niobidarum grex tibi foret plenus
 si spado Coresus Dindymusque non esset.*

“By Marulla, Cinna, you have become the father of seven -
 not children, for not one of them is yours, nor yet a friend’s,
 or a neighbor’s son; but conceived on truckle beds and mats,
 they reveal their mother’s escapages by their heads. This
 one, that stalks like a Moor with curly hair, confesses himself
 the offspring of Santra the cook. But that one, with flat
 nostrils and blubber lips, is the very image of Panychus the
 wrestling coach. Who but knows that the third is the baker’s,
 if he knows and sees blear-eyed Dama? The fourth, with
 catamite’s brow and pale complexion, was born to you from
 your favorite Lygdus. Sodomize your son, if you like; no sin

in that. Ah, but this one with the pointed head and long ears
 that move like donkeys' are wont to do, who denies that he is
 the son of Cyrtus the natural? Two sisters, one black, the
 other red, are Crotus the flautist's and Carpus the bailiff's.
 You would now have a troop as numerous as Niobe's, if
 Coresus and Dindymus had not been eunuchs."

While it is lengthy, it is also necessary to show this poem in its entirety because there is much to discuss. Again, Martial is verbally attacking a woman, however, she is a married woman this time around. This epigram discusses the issue of elite women committing adultery with their household slaves right under the nose of their husbands and would have the gall to walk around with these children as if nothing were amiss.⁵⁰ Each child depicted has some form of a physical trait that is similar to one of the slaves, many of which were foreign characteristics. Like other poems, this poem is an exaggeration but did discuss a real issue. However, Martial goes to the extreme by having each child fathered by a different man which is evident by their appearances.

The first child he discusses is one with curly hair, a trait that Martial himself is not fond of, as seen in 4.42. The second child also has traits that Martial is not fond of, specifically a flat nose and ugly lips, once again present in 4.42. Each child has some undesirable physical quality that paints them as 'other' when compared to their father, including their skin tone. The fifth child is particularly interesting because he appears to have some sort of physical ailment, a true medical condition related to his head. It is noted that deformities of the head indicate low intelligence.⁵¹ The inclusion of girls is not

⁵⁰ Watson and Watson, *Select Epigrams*, 233.

⁵¹ Watson and Watson, *Select Epigrams*, 237.

surprising as the comparison with Niobe's children is upcoming and Niobe had both boys and girls. What is interesting to note is how un-Roman-like each child is, almost where it makes it seem like her infidelity would have been okay had she been cheating with a Roman citizen, rather than foreign slaves. Martial ends the epigram with a witty comment reporting that there is good news: Cinna could have had more illegitimate children had two of the men not been infertile. This mention of eunuchs is not surprising as Martial discusses in other epigrams how eunuchs were favoured as lovers specifically for the fact that they could not sire any children. What is surprising is the fact that Marulla did not have sex with just the infertile slaves, she had sex with seven others, creating a child with each who is physically unattractive that they had become physical embodiments of her lack of self-control and her lack of care for her husband's *virtus*.

CONCLUSION

The hope for this essay is for others to have a greater appreciation for the comedic value of invective poetry and the hidden messages left between the lines. Messages that are sometimes hard to decipher with a modern mindset. His epigrams were meant to stand on the side of his readers while assaulting those who were full of vice. As mentioned earlier, Martial portrayed himself as a 'normal' male within higher society who may have believed in such high morals, even while being hypocrites themselves. Martial notes that no one is perfect, but that there is a line that Romans believed could not be crossed. This line seemed to appear after a certain age, an age where youth has fled and vulnerability has set in. Something else to note is the concept of the authorial "I" and who that first-person persona is really for, rather than the writer. However, every book written does have its intended audience whether it's a textbook or fiction or a how-to book. Every piece of literature has its audience and Martial is just another example of how to manipulate already set morals and societal standards into book sales.

The fact that people still read and mostly comment on Martial even today shows that, for the most part, his work is no longer misunderstood as something completely obscene. Rather, he is one of the many well-known Roman literary figures. Yes, he has not been studied as much as Ovid or Virgil, but he is still thought of as the father of modern epigram. Something that he is traditionally known for is his deceiving use of the first person, of who the "I" is in his poems. How Martial created this persona for his audience based on their dislikes and prejudices was smart, especially for someone who chose a form of poetry that was seen as paltry compared to others. His use of physical

ailments and defects to discuss moral issues was like an early form of political cartoons, minus the drawings. Yet, he was able to illustrate these typical characters and how their physical traits could speak volumes, with the right verse. It is obvious why he was so popular, as he had “[an] audience of sophisticated readers who knew, for instance, the epigrammatic tradition in which he worked [and] showed their appreciation for Martial’s literary skills by continuing to purchase his poems and, no doubt, to look forward to the next available booklet.”⁵² His use of physical traits also allowed him to create a lively performance on paper where he criticised those who could, or have, tipped the balance of morality. This was possible by feeding on the Latin traditions of comedy and what was known as satire to create an invective with parts centred around recognizable characters. With epigram, Martial had more freedom to commentate and discuss the society he lived in, even with lots of reading in-between the lines. Yet, he is not the first to use such dark humour to represent immorality as “such black humor...has a moral basis in ancient thought: physical defects mirror moral deficiencies.”⁵³

While many of the physical traits first seemed out of place, it is fascinating to realise that they were a part of literary tradition in the Greco-Roman world. These were stock characters that not only Martial put a twist on, but past and present writers. Their presence was also necessary so that these characters could be both attached and morphed into caricatures of immorality and disappointment. However, they were not the only characters that Martial would put his focus on, the reader also had to remember the victim(s), even those who were not directly addressed. In his discrepancies among the comedic tropes, one could see that Martial sometimes walked a tight line of who was to

⁵² Conley, 49.

⁵³ Sullivan, *Martial: The Unexpected Classic*, 168.

blame; the perpetrator or the victim. The best example of this lies within the epigrams featuring legacy hunters. For some, there was no line between the perpetrator and the victim and both were guilty of deceit.

Again, he is not the first to use typical motifs to represent dishonourable morals such as greediness and loss of self-control being presented by notions such as strong sexual appetites or the search for an easy inheritance, but he did it well. Vanity, dishonesty and an inability to accept ageing were portrayed by the use of wigs, dyed hair, and false teeth is a somewhat aggressive makeover, both in body and mindset. Decadence and corruption from wealth are portrayed by gout, typically within the feet. An interesting juxtaposition for men who lounge around all day, but an easy target for Martial. One of the biggest issues to get used to is the use of “explicit verbal obscenity which was a distinguishing feature of Roman, as opposed to Greek, epigram.”⁵⁴ Jokes using vocabulary that modern societies would call inappropriate were mildly popular until around the time of Constantine.

What should be gained from this essay is that there were issues within Rome, specifically when it came to appearances. These issues surrounded not only physical appearances but also moral appearances. One of the biggest issues was hypocrisy within ancient Rome, an issue that is exaggerated within Martial’s fictional world but done with finesse. While not all of Martial’s epigrams dealt with the social issues of everyday life and the hypocrisy that was ever-present, many did. All of the epigrams discussed within this essay deal with the hypocrisy of a society where morals like the *mos maiorum* were put on a pedestal and yet were never followed once doors were closed. Yet, the way that every word and every poem was treated, many were so

⁵⁴ Watson, “Epigram”, 203.

bizarrely over-the-top that readership could only imagine these issues happening within Martial's world. While there is something to be said about the scale of morality and Rome, it's not like the topic of hypocrisy was discussed behind closed doors. If it were, Martial would not have reached as many readers as he did. The evidence of this lies in his surviving materials and his continued presence and influence over thousands of years of writers and scholars.

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